

Pawnshop King – Full Game Design Document

Working Title

Pawnshop King

One-line pitch

A high-stakes pawn shop strategy sim where every item might be fake, stolen, cursed, or worth a fortune — and every customer might be lying to you.

Short elevator pitch

Run a shady pawn shop in a city full of desperate customers, collectors, thieves, scammers, and hidden treasures. Buy low, inspect items, negotiate hard, repair, authenticate, and resell for profit — but every deal carries risk. Some items are counterfeit. Some are stolen. Some are cursed. Some are part of rare collections that can make you rich if you spot them in time. Grow from a tiny debt-ridden shop into a legendary trading empire while balancing cash flow, reputation, police attention, underworld pressure, and your own greed.

1. Vision

1.1 The fantasy

The player fantasy is not “I own a store.”

The real fantasy is:

- **I can spot value where other people see junk**
- **I can read liars and manipulate desperate customers**
- **I can take risks, flip rare finds, and outsmart everyone**
- **I can build a shadow economy from a tiny, sketchy pawn shop**
- **I can become rich because I know what to buy, when to hold, and who to sell to**

The game should feel like a mix of:

- **shop management**
- **negotiation**
- **deception detection**
- **collection hunting**
- **risk/reward strategy**
- **economic snowballing**

This is **not** a cozy “decorate shelves and vibe” game. It is a **greedy, tense, highly replayable deal-making game**.

2. Pillars

Pillar 1 – Every customer is a gamble

Every customer interaction should feel like opening a smart loot box:

- Is the item real?
- Is it stolen?
- Is the customer lying?
- Is it secretly part of a rare set?
- Is it broken in a way I can cheaply fix?
- Should I buy now, hold it, repair it, or flip it immediately?

Pillar 2 – Greed creates stories

The player should constantly feel:

- “I can squeeze a little more profit out of this”
- “I should hold this one longer”
- “I should risk buying this suspicious item”
- “I know this is shady, but the upside is huge”

Pillar 3 – Simple actions, deep consequences

The player mostly does a few things:

- inspect
- negotiate
- buy
- repair
- sell
- hold
- authenticate
- hide / report / move suspicious items

But those actions create complex outcomes through:

- cash flow pressure
- reputation
- black market relations
- collector demand
- police heat

- cursed item penalties
- debt deadlines

Pillar 4 – Strong “one more day” loop

The game should be structured in short in-game days. The ideal player feeling:

- “Just one more customer”
- “Just one more day until the collector arrives”
- “I need to see if this item turns out to be fake”
- “I’ll stop after I sell this watch”

Pillar 5 – Solo-dev feasible

The game should be deep through **systems**, not through massive 3D complexity. The first production target is a **UI-heavy / management-first vertical slice**, not a huge immersive sim.

3. Genre and platform

Genre

Single-player strategy / management sim / deal-making sim / economy roguelite-lite

Platform priority

1. **PC / Steam**
2. Steam Deck compatibility if feasible
3. Optional console later only if the game succeeds

Engine

Unity

Art scope recommendation

Prefer one of these:

- **2.5D management presentation**
- **fixed shop camera**
- **simple stylized 3D with UI-heavy flow**
- **first-person only if heavily scoped down**

For solo development, the safest path is **non-walking or very light walking** and heavy focus on **menus, item cards, deal flow, and decision systems**.

4. Game structure

Core structure

The game is divided into **days**.

Each day: 1. The shop opens 2. Customers arrive with items 3. The player inspects, negotiates, buys or rejects 4. The player manages inventory and selling 5. The player may repair, authenticate, bundle, or store items 6. Special events may happen 7. The day ends 8. Expenses, risks, and market changes are resolved

The loop repeats until:

- the player clears debt and reaches the next milestone
- the player fails financially
- the player loses due to heat / collapse in specific modes
- the player reaches a campaign chapter ending

5. Core gameplay loop

5.1 Moment-to-moment loop

For each customer: 1. Customer enters with one or more items 2. Player sees basic visible information 3. Player inspects item(s) 4. Player evaluates customer behavior and item condition 5. Player decides whether to:

- make an offer
- ask questions
- run a quick authenticity check
- reject the deal
- Customer responds
- Negotiation happens
- Deal outcome:
 - bought
 - rejected
 - customer leaves angry
 - customer leaves happy
 - item flagged as suspicious
 - Item enters inventory if bought

5.2 Mid-level loop per day

During a day:

- serve multiple customers
- decide which inventory to sell now vs hold
- use limited repair/authentication actions
- respond to random events
- watch cash flow, reputation, heat, and storage

5.3 Long-term loop

Across multiple days:

- pay debt
 - upgrade shop
 - unlock tools and staff
 - build dealer/collector/black-market relationships
 - specialize in categories
 - survive bad luck and exploit good luck
 - transform the shop into a serious operation
-

6. Game modes

6.1 Main mode – Story / Campaign

The player inherits or acquires a failing pawn shop with debt attached. Campaign progression introduces new mechanics over time:

- basic pawn buying
- counterfeit risk
- stolen goods
- collectors
- repairs
- cursed / unusual items
- police / black market pressure
- advanced auctions and VIP clients

6.2 Optional future mode – Endless / Sandbox

No hard ending. Focus on score, wealth, collections, and efficiency.

6.3 Optional future mode – Challenge Runs

Examples:

- No black market
 - Only legal business
 - Antique-only run
 - Cursed-only run
 - High police surveillance city
 - Pay debt in 14 days
-

7. Setting and tone

Tone

The tone should be:

- gritty but playful
- greedy, tense, and funny
- occasionally dark
- full of strange people and stories

It should not be grim realism all the time. There should be room for:

- absurd customers
- weird item histories
- cursed collectibles
- suspiciously emotional sellers
- chaotic market events

Setting concept

A dense urban neighborhood where:

- people are broke
- collectors lurk
- thieves operate
- police monitor stolen goods
- scammers test your intelligence
- weird treasures appear in ordinary hands

The setting should support both:

- realism (watches, gold, electronics, instruments)
- stylized weirdness (cursed idols, occult relics, bizarre memorabilia)

8. Core resources and stats

The game should stay readable. For the MVP, use a compact stat model.

8.1 Player / shop resources

1. Cash

Current liquid money. Used for:

- buying items
- paying daily costs
- upgrades
- repairs
- authentication fees
- staff
- debt payments

2. Reputation

How customers, collectors, and the market view your shop. High reputation:

- better customers
- better deals
- more collector access
- fewer people assuming you are a scammer

Low reputation:

- worse customers
- fewer honest sellers
- more scammers
- more people refusing your offers

3. Heat

Attention from police, inspectors, and authorities. Heat rises when:

- buying stolen goods
- dealing with known criminals
- hiding contraband
- failing inspections
- repeated suspicious transactions

High heat can cause:

- inspections
- confiscations
- temporary shop closure
- fines
- loss of reputation

4. Underworld Favor

Represents relationship with thieves, fences, smugglers, shady brokers. High favor:

- access to rare illegal goods
- better black-market buyers
- warnings about raids
- stolen item leads

Low favor:

- fewer shady opportunities
- possible intimidation / theft / sabotage if betrayed

5. Debt / Pressure

Main campaign timer pressure. The player starts with debt and must pay on schedule. If debt milestones are missed:

- penalties
- intimidation
- repossession
- game over in some modes

9. Secondary hidden item values

Every item should have several internal values, not just one price.

For each item, track:

- **BaseValue** – fair market value in normal legal conditions
- **CurrentCondition** – condition percentage / state
- **Authenticity** – real / fake / uncertain
- **StolenFlag** – legal risk level
- **RarityTier**
- **CollectorTags**
- **RepairPotential**

- **CurseState** (for supernatural items if enabled in campaign)
- **DemandModifier**
- **SellerAskingPrice**
- **PlayerKnowledgeState** – what the player currently knows vs doesn't know

This is critical: The player should rarely know everything with certainty at first glance.

10. Item system

10.1 Item categories for MVP

Start with a manageable set of categories that create different gameplay patterns.

Category list

1. **Watches**
2. **Jewelry**
3. **Electronics**
4. **Musical Instruments**
5. **Retro Gaming / Collectibles**
6. **Antiques / Curios**
7. **Luxury Accessories**
8. **Tools / Practical Goods**

Do **not** try to ship 100 categories. The depth should come from item states, authenticity, demand, and negotiation.

10.2 Item attributes

Each item should have:

Identity

- item id
- category
- name
- description
- brand / maker
- year or era if relevant

Economics

- base value
- min / max possible market swing

- buyer demand tags
- sell destination preference

Risk

- fake chance or authenticity status
- stolen chance / risk tier
- curse chance if applicable
- repair difficulty
- police interest level

Presentation

- sprite / icon / model reference
 - condition descriptor
 - visible clues
 - hidden clues
-

10.3 Item states

An item can be:

- authentic
- counterfeit
- stolen
- damaged
- incomplete
- restored
- cursed
- collector-grade
- mass-market junk
- sentimental but worthless
- rare but only to the right buyer

An item may have multiple states at once:

- authentic + damaged + stolen
 - fake + polished + convincing
 - rare + cursed + highly valuable to occult buyer
-

11. The knowledge model

This is one of the most important systems.

Principle

The **item's true state** and the **player's knowledge of the item** are separate things.

Example

A watch may truly be:

- authentic
- worth 1,200
- lightly damaged
- stolen
- part of a rare collector set

But the player may currently know only:

- it looks authentic
- it is scratched
- the seller claims it belonged to an uncle
- there is a suspicious serial number

The player can improve knowledge through:

- visual inspection
- negotiation tells
- tools
- staff
- authentication services
- experience / perks

This separation is what creates tension and replayability.

12. Inspection system

12.1 Goal

Inspection should feel like a mini strategy layer, not a giant realism simulator.

The player should inspect an item through a few actions and clues, not through 20 screens.

12.2 Inspection actions for MVP

For an item, the player can do some of the following:

- **Visual Check**

- identify obvious damage
- notice branding, wear, missing parts
- reveal surface clues
- **Weight / Material Check**
- useful for jewelry, luxury items, antiques
- **Function Test**
- power on electronics
- test guitar electronics
- wind a watch
- check console boot
- **Serial / Marking Check**
- compare against fake indicators
- identify stolen serial match risk later with upgrades
- **Quick UV / Magnifier Check**
- reveals authenticity clues on certain items
- **Ask Provenance Question**
- "Where did you get it?"
- "Why are you selling it?"
- "Do you have the box / certificate?"

Each action reveals clues, not always certainty.

12.3 Clue system

Items and customers generate clues.

Example clue types

- "logo engraving is slightly off-center"
- "serial sticker looks recently replaced"
- "gold weight seems low"
- "customer avoids eye contact when discussing origin"
- "item smells like smoke / basement / seawater"

- “packaging is suspiciously perfect for its age”
- “back panel screws were recently opened”

Clues should push probabilities and player judgment, not always give exact answers.

13. Negotiation system

This is the heart of the game feel.

13.1 Goal

Negotiation should be:

- fast
- readable
- tactical
- different per customer type

13.2 Negotiation structure

After inspection, the player can:

- reject
- make an offer
- ask follow-up questions
- stall
- flag for further review
- accept customer's asking price

13.3 Customer parameters

Each customer has:

- patience
- honesty
- desperation
- confidence
- greed
- social status
- category knowledge
- criminal risk
- mood

These values affect how they react to offers and pressure.

13.4 Negotiation actions

The player can use actions like:

Soft Offer

A fair but profitable offer.

Lowball

Aggressive underpricing. Can increase profit if accepted, but hurts reputation if overused.

Pressure

Call out flaws or uncertainty to drive price down.

Sympathy Angle

Use customer desperation / urgency to influence deal.

Bluff Expertise

Pretend to know more than you do.

Walk Away

Risk losing the deal to pressure the customer.

Ask for Add-ons

Request certificates, accessories, original box, charger, etc.

13.5 Negotiation outcomes

Possible outcomes:

- customer accepts
 - customer counters
 - customer gets offended and leaves
 - customer reveals new information
 - customer lowers demand if desperate
 - customer raises suspicion by overreacting
 - customer returns later with lower expectations
 - customer blacklists the shop for a while if treated badly
-

14. Customer system

14.1 Customer design goals

Customers are the game's main content engine. They should not feel like generic vending machines.

Each customer should have:

- a type / archetype
- item(s)
- goals
- risk profile
- negotiation behavior
- possible story/event hooks

14.2 Customer archetypes for MVP

Create a limited but flavorful set.

1. Desperate Seller

Needs cash fast.

- easier to lowball
- may bring low-condition items
- often returns

2. Casual Home Seller

Selling random inherited junk.

- unpredictable value
- low item knowledge
- good source of hidden gems

3. Amateur Scammer

Trying to pass fake goods.

- may panic under pressure
- not very skilled

4. Professional Fence

Moves stolen goods.

- dangerous but profitable
- raises heat
- improves underworld favor if handled

5. Collector in Need

Brings niche valuable items but knows their worth.

- hard negotiation
- can become future buyer contact

6. Tech Flipper

Brings electronics, often with hidden issues.

- moderate knowledge
- fast deals

7. Elderly Inheritance Seller

Brings antiques / jewelry / heirlooms.

- often undervalues items
- reputation-sensitive

8. Rich Eccentric

Rare weird items, high demands, strange behavior.

9. Addict / Chaotic Seller

Volatile, emotional, fast deal pressure.

10. Repeat Local

Builds long-term relationship and memory.

14.3 Customer memory

For long-term depth, the game should track at least some recurring customers.

Customers may remember:

- if you humiliated them
- if you were fair
- if you caught them lying
- if you helped them
- if you reported them
- if you consistently lowball too hard

This creates:

- repeat customers
 - revenge / retaliation
 - loyalty
 - future opportunities
-

15. Selling system

Buying is only half the game. Selling should be strategic.

15.1 Sell channels

The player can sell items through multiple channels.

1. Shopfront shelf sale

Simple local retail sale.

- lower margins on some items
- steady cash flow
- reputation-friendly

2. Collector direct sale

Best for rare items with matching tags.

- highest upside
- requires contacts and patience

3. Auction / special market

Good for high-end antiques, collectibles, luxury items.

- delayed payout
- variable outcome

- fees

4. Online marketplace

Good for electronics, collectibles, broad demand items.

- takes time
- risk of fraud / returns later if expanded

5. Black market / fence sale

Fast, high-risk, useful for stolen items.

- increases underworld favor
 - may reduce heat if moved out quickly
 - may hurt reputation if exposed
-

15.2 Why sell channels matter

They create the “hold vs flip” decision.

A rare watch might be:

- sold today for 900 at the shop
- sold to a collector in 3 days for 1,600
- sold quietly through the black market for 1,100 if stolen
- authenticated first, then auctioned for 2,200

That is where greed and planning come from.

16. Collector system

Collectors are one of the strongest progression and dopamine systems in the game.

16.1 Collector basics

Collectors are recurring buyers with specific interests:

- vintage watches
- military antiques
- retro consoles
- occult relics
- rare guitars
- luxury fountain pens

- signed sports memorabilia

16.2 Collector requests

Collectors may request:

- one specific item
- one item with certain tags
- a full set
- an item in a minimum condition
- an item before a deadline

16.3 Why collectors matter

Collectors create:

- long-term planning
- inventory holding decisions
- “aha” moments when junk becomes valuable
- category specialization

16.4 Set completion examples

Examples:

- 3 watches from the same Swiss brand line
- 4 cartridges from a retro franchise
- matching silver tea service pieces
- cursed occult set for a hidden buyer route

Set completion is one of the best “just one more day” mechanics.

17. Fake / counterfeit system

This must be a major pillar, not a side mechanic.

17.1 Design goals

Counterfeits should:

- create tension
- reward learning and tools
- punish greed and laziness
- produce memorable losses and near-misses

17.2 Fake levels

Not every fake is equal.

Fake tiers

1. **Obvious fake**
2. **Decent fake**
3. **High-quality counterfeit**
4. **Hybrid / repaired fake**
5. **Forgery with fake documents**

17.3 Consequences of buying a fake

- immediate loss if resold cheaply
- reputation damage if sold to wrong buyer
- collector relationship damage
- police / fraud issue in advanced cases
- opportunity cost of tying up cash

17.4 Counterfeit mitigation

The player can reduce risk through:

- better tools
 - category expertise
 - staff
 - paid authentication
 - customer reading
 - choosing to avoid risky categories
-

18. Stolen goods system

This is a major risk/reward layer.

18.1 Stolen states

Items can be:

- clean
- suspicious
- likely stolen
- confirmed stolen
- "hot" / currently searched

18.2 Buying stolen goods

Benefits:

- often cheaper
- access to rare items
- black market opportunities

Costs:

- heat
- confiscation
- fines
- loss of reputation
- criminal entanglement

18.3 Player choices with suspicious goods

After buying, the player can:

- sell quickly to black market
- hide item in back room
- hold and risk inspection
- pay to alter / clean identifying marks
- report it to police for reputation gain
- return it to a victim in specific story events

This should create hard moral and economic choices.

19. Cursed / supernatural item system (optional in early campaign, but strong differentiator)

This is one of the best ways to stop the game from being “just another simulator.”

19.1 Positioning

The cursed item layer should be introduced gradually and not dominate the whole game immediately.

Early game:

- mostly realistic pawn shop simulation

Mid game:

- rumors of weird items
- one suspicious relic
- strange recurring penalties

Later:

- occult buyers
- cursed collections
- high-risk high-reward supernatural market

19.2 Curse effects

A cursed item might:

- reduce reputation while stored
- cause random bad customer moods
- attract weird buyers
- increase theft chance
- distort appraisals
- drain cash through strange events
- unlock special collectors or black market branches

19.3 Why keep this system

Because it gives the game identity. A cursed relic that is worth a fortune but poisons your week is far more memorable than “another gold ring.”

20. Repair and restoration system

20.1 Goal

Repair should be simple, strategic, and category-specific enough to matter.

20.2 Repair states

Items may have:

- cosmetic damage
- functional damage
- missing parts
- dirt / oxidation / grime
- packaging loss

- severe structural damage

20.3 Player options

The player can:

- clean
- repair in-house
- send to specialist
- do nothing
- sell as-is

20.4 Repair tradeoffs

Repairing costs:

- time
- cash
- tool durability or staff time
- possible risk of damaging authenticity on antiques

Repairing can:

- raise value
- remove obvious flaws for negotiation
- unlock collector sale
- accidentally reduce value if done poorly on antiques

21. Authentication system

Authentication should be a strategic cost, not something the player always does.

Options

- no authentication
- quick in-house check
- paid expert appraisal
- premium certification for auctions / collectors

Tradeoffs

Authentication costs money and time but reduces uncertainty and can massively raise sell value.

The player should constantly decide:

- “Do I trust my instincts and flip now?”
 - “Or pay to confirm and maybe triple the value?”
-

22. Reputation system

22.1 Reputation audiences

Reputation can be split internally into:

- **Public Reputation**
- **Collector Reputation**
- **Underworld Reputation**

For MVP, you may keep one main Reputation stat and one Underworld Favor stat. Later, split if needed.

22.2 Reputation effects

High reputation:

- better customers
- more repeat business
- higher patience during negotiation
- better event opportunities

Low reputation:

- more scammers
 - fewer legitimate valuables
 - harder collector access
 - more suspicion and hostility
-

23. Shop upgrades

Upgrades are the long-term progression engine.

23.1 Upgrade categories

Shop space

- larger front display

- bigger back room
- secure storage
- premium display cases

Tools

- magnifier
- UV light
- precision scale
- electronics tester
- luxury watch opener / tester
- antique reference database
- counterfeit scanner upgrade

Security

- cameras
- stronger locks
- hidden safe
- anti-theft systems

Selling infrastructure

- collector contacts board
- auction access
- online listing station
- repair bench

Staff

- appraiser
- repair technician
- security guard
- runner / assistant
- occult consultant if supernatural layer is active

24. Staff system (post-MVP but important in GDD)

Staff should not be mandatory in the first prototype, but should be planned.

Staff roles

Appraiser

Improves identification and valuation.

Technician

Repairs electronics and practical items.

Restorer

Restores antiques and collectibles.

Security Guard

Reduces theft and intimidation events.

Clerk

Handles basic customers, speeds throughput.

Occult Specialist

Deals with cursed items, identifies weird effects.

Each staff member can have:

- wage
- skill level
- loyalty
- flaws
- category specialties

25. Event system

Events are essential to stop the game from becoming repetitive.

Event categories

1. **Customer Events**
 2. **Market Events**
 3. **Debt / pressure events**
 4. **Police / heat events**
 5. **Black market events**
 6. **Collector opportunities**
 7. **Theft / sabotage**
 8. **Cursed / supernatural events**
-

25.1 Example event types

Customer event

A customer comes back furious claiming you sold them a fake accessory.

- apologize and refund
- refuse and risk reputation
- investigate whether they swapped the item
- call security

Market event

Retro gaming prices spike this week.

- sell held stock now
- buy aggressively from new customers
- risk a bubble collapse next week

Police event

An inspector wants access to recent high-value transactions.

- cooperate
- bribe a clerk to stall
- move suspicious stock to hidden storage
- burn underworld favor to get warning time

Collector event

A collector is in town for 48 hours and paying double for military watches.

Debt event

Loan shark demands an early partial payment.

Supernatural event

A carved idol causes all customers to lowball harder until it leaves your inventory.

26. Economy design

26.1 Economic pillars

The economy should create constant tension between:

- liquidity vs profit
- safe flips vs risky jackpots
- legal trade vs dirty money
- immediate survival vs long-term growth

26.2 Sources of money

- customer buys and sells
- shopfront sales
- collector deals
- auctions
- black market flips
- event rewards
- completing collection contracts

26.3 Expenses

- daily rent
- debt payments
- staff wages
- utilities
- repair fees
- authentication fees
- fines
- upgrades

26.4 Economic danger

The player should be able to go broke through:

- overpaying for junk
 - holding inventory too long
 - buying too many suspicious goods
 - failing to pay debt
 - taking cursed items at bad times
 - spending on upgrades too early
-

27. Failure states and victory states

27.1 Campaign failure states

- debt milestone missed beyond recovery
- cash goes negative and obligations cannot be paid
- heat reaches critical threshold and shop is shut down
- special story fail states if used

27.2 Campaign victory state

Primary campaign success example:

- pay off inherited debt
- expand to a target shop tier
- reach a wealth threshold
- survive long enough to become “Pawnshop King”

Optional late-game goals:

- own multiple shops
 - dominate specific item markets
 - complete legendary collector chains
 - build legal or criminal empire path
-

28. Progression structure

28.1 Campaign chapters suggestion

Chapter 1 – Survival

- basic buying and selling
- debt pressure
- common item categories
- simple repairs

Chapter 2 – Risk

- counterfeit items introduced
- more difficult negotiations
- reputation starts to matter more

Chapter 3 – Heat

- stolen goods
- police inspections
- underworld offers

Chapter 4 – Specialists

- collectors
- set building
- auctions
- advanced authentication

Chapter 5 – The Strange Market

- cursed items
- hidden buyers
- rare event chains
- endgame wealth opportunities

29. Meta progression and replayability

Even outside campaign, the game needs replayability.

Replayable systems

- random item generation
- customer archetype variety
- fluctuating market demand
- different debt / starting conditions
- collector rotation
- cursed item variance
- black market opportunities
- perk / upgrade order differences

Optional roguelite-lite layer

You can add unlockable starting perks between runs:

- better haggling
- lower inspection cost
- extra collector slot
- improved counterfeit spotting
- stronger opening cash position

This is optional and should not distract from the core business sim.

30. MVP scope

The MVP must prove the core loop is fun. It does **not** need the whole fantasy.

MVP goal

A vertical slice where the player can:

- run a pawn shop for several in-game days
- inspect and negotiate with customers
- buy and store items
- sell through at least 2 channels
- deal with fake / stolen risk in basic form
- feel debt pressure
- experience “one more day” compulsion

MVP features

Core stats

- Cash
- Reputation
- Heat
- Debt

Core categories

- Watches
- Jewelry
- Electronics
- Retro Collectibles

Item states in MVP

- authentic / fake
- damaged / clean
- suspicious stolen / clean
- common / rare

Customer archetypes in MVP

- Desperate Seller
- Casual Seller
- Amateur Scammer
- Fence
- Collector-type buyer event

Selling channels in MVP

- shopfront sale
- collector sale / special buyer
- optional black market simplified

Systems in MVP

- daily loop
- item generation
- inspection clues
- negotiation
- inventory
- debt timer
- reputation changes
- heat changes
- 20–30 events

Excluded from MVP unless time allows

- full staff system
 - deep shop decoration
 - occult / cursed system
 - multiple stores
 - online marketplace
 - full auction system
 - first-person movement complexity
-

31. Suggested MVP content numbers

Item count

Start with roughly **40–60 item definitions** total, not hundreds.

Example:

- 12 watches
- 10 jewelry items
- 12 electronics
- 12 retro collectibles
- 6 antiques or curios if needed

Customer archetypes

4–6

Event count

20–30

Collector requests

8–12

Upgrades

12–20

Day count for first campaign slice

10–20 days

32. UX / UI design

32.1 Main screens

A. Shop screen

Primary day gameplay screen. Shows:

- current customer
- item on counter
- visible inspection panel
- player offer controls
- top bar with key resources

B. Inventory screen

Shows:

- all owned items
- filters by category / risk / condition / rarity
- hold / sell / repair / inspect / flag actions

C. Sell / market screen

Shows:

- local sell price
- collector offers

- black market options if unlocked
- pending special buyers

D. Upgrade screen

Shows:

- tools
- shop improvements
- security
- storage

E. Day summary screen

Shows:

- daily profit/loss
- new heat
- reputation change
- debt countdown
- events resolved

F. Collector / contact screen

Shows:

- known collectors
- wanted items
- deadlines
- underworld contacts if unlocked

32.2 Main gameplay HUD

Top bar should show:

- Cash
- Reputation
- Heat
- Debt due / days left
- Day number

Current customer panel should show:

- name / archetype hint
- mood
- asking price

- suspicion meter if discovered
 - known item clues
-

33. Art direction

Recommended direction

Do **not** chase realism-first. Go for a stylized look that supports readability.

Good art goals

- recognizable item silhouettes
- strong item card presentation
- character portraits or simple 3D customer models
- readable rarity / risk indicators
- cozy-grimy shop atmosphere

Visual inspirations to target in feel

- shady but charming storefront
- warm desk lighting
- cluttered shelves
- hidden back-room tension
- item glamour shots for valuable finds

The most important thing visually is: **items and deal decisions must be legible and satisfying.**

34. Audio direction

Audio priorities

- satisfying cash register / deal sounds
- subtle customer reactions
- UI click / inspect sounds
- day-end summary sting
- tension audio when heat rises
- eerie sound design later for cursed items

Audio should reinforce:

- greed
- suspicion
- relief

- jackpot moments
-

35. Technical architecture for Unity

Recommended architecture approach

Use a **data-driven architecture** with:

- ScriptableObjects for definitions
 - serializable runtime state objects
 - managers/services for core systems
 - event-driven UI updates where possible
-

36. Core systems list

Mandatory core systems

- GameManager
- DayManager
- EconomySystem
- CustomerSystem
- NegotiationSystem
- InspectionSystem
- InventorySystem
- ItemGenerationSystem
- MarketSystem
- EventSystem
- DebtSystem
- HeatSystem
- SaveLoadSystem
- UIManager

Later systems

- CollectorSystem
 - UnderworldSystem
 - CurseSystem
 - StaffSystem
 - AuctionSystem
-

37. Suggested folder structure

```
Assets/  
  _Game/  
    Art/  
    Audio/  
    Prefabs/  
      UI/  
      Customers/  
      Items/  
    Scenes/  
      Bootstrap  
      MainGame  
      Test  
    Scripts/  
      Core/  
        GameManager.cs  
        DayManager.cs  
        GameBootstrap.cs  
      Data/  
        Definitions/  
          Items/  
          Customers/  
          Events/  
          Upgrades/  
          Collectors/  
        Runtime/  
          SaveData/  
          State/  
      Systems/  
        Economy/  
        Customers/  
        Negotiation/  
        Inspection/  
        Inventory/  
        Market/  
        Events/  
        Debt/  
        Heat/  
        SaveLoad/  
      UI/  
        HUD/  
        Inventory/  
        Negotiation/  
        Market/  
        Upgrades/
```

38. Data model design

38.1 ScriptableObject definitions

ItemDefinition

Fields:

- id
- displayName
- category
- baseValueMin
- baseValueMax
- rarityTier
- possibleConditions
- possibleTags
- fakeChance
- stolenChance
- repairProfiles
- collectorTags
- visual references

CustomerArchetypeDefinition

Fields:

- id
- displayName
- patience range
- desperation range
- honesty range
- greed range
- category preferences
- dialogue pool
- risk profile
- possible item categories

EventDefinition

Fields:

- id
- title
- description
- trigger conditions
- choices
- outcomes

UpgradeDefinition

Fields:

- id
- name
- cost
- prerequisites
- effects

CollectorDefinition

Fields:

- id
 - displayName
 - desired tags
 - patience / deadline style
 - offer modifiers
-

38.2 Runtime state classes

GameState

Contains:

- current day
- cash
- reputation
- heat
- debt state
- inventory state
- active events
- unlocked upgrades
- known collectors

- current shop stats

ItemInstance

Contains:

- unique id
- definition id
- actual base value roll
- condition state
- authenticity state
- stolen state
- repair state
- collector tags
- known clues
- player knowledge flags
- acquisition price
- acquisition source

CustomerInstance

Contains:

- archetype id
- generated stats
- mood
- item list
- current negotiation state
- memory flags if recurring

DebtState

Contains:

- total debt
- next payment amount
- days until payment
- missed payments

ShopState

Contains:

- storage size
- display size
- security level
- installed tools
- unlocked systems

39. Example system responsibilities

GameManager

- initializes save or new game
- owns high-level state transitions
- starts / ends days
- coordinates scene systems

DayManager

- day start setup
- customer queue generation
- day end resolution
- daily expense processing

CustomerSystem

- generates customer instances
- picks items based on archetype and progression
- manages repeat customer chance

InspectionSystem

- processes inspection actions
- reveals clues
- updates player knowledge state on item

NegotiationSystem

- handles offer logic
- computes acceptance chance / counter behavior
- applies reputation effects

InventorySystem

- add / remove items
- move between shelf / storage / hidden storage
- query items by tags and state

MarketSystem

- calculate sale values by channel
- collector offer generation

- daily market modifiers

EventSystem

- fire random events
- resolve outcomes
- inject special customers or modifiers

DebtSystem

- track debt milestones and penalties

HeatSystem

- track suspicion
- trigger inspections and police events

SaveLoadSystem

- serialize game state
 - load persistent campaign state
-

40. First playable vertical slice target

The first playable build should prove the loop in the smallest possible way.

Vertical slice requirements

- start a campaign with debt
 - play through at least 5–7 days
 - see 4–6 customers per day
 - inspect items
 - negotiate prices
 - buy and store inventory
 - sell items through at least one immediate channel and one delayed higher-value channel
 - see fake / suspicious stolen outcomes
 - experience one inspection / heat event
 - upgrade at least one tool
 - feel the urge to keep playing one more day
-

41. Sample day flow for MVP

Day start

- daily debt reminder
- market modifier shown
- possible event notification

Customer 1

Casual seller with vintage watch

- visible scratch
- unknown authenticity
- medium asking price
- maybe rare tag

Customer 2

Desperate seller with retro console bundle

- one item broken
- one cartridge rare
- low patience

Customer 3

Scammer with fake gold ring

- subtle clue
- tries to rush deal

Midday

Player chooses:

- sell old inventory to local buyer
- pay for authentication on one item
- hold rare item for collector

Customer 4

Fence with suspicious phone

- cheap price

- high heat risk

End of day

- rent + debt tick
- one collector request appears
- reputation and heat updated

That alone can already be a compelling demo if tuned well.

42. Balancing priorities

When balancing the game, prioritize these feelings:

The player should feel smart when:

- spotting a fake from clues
- lowballing a desperate seller just enough
- holding the right item for the right buyer
- avoiding a stolen-goods trap
- repairing something cheaply and flipping it big

The player should feel pain when:

- overpaying for junk
- getting caught with hot goods
- selling a collector item too early
- ignoring debt pressure
- missing a clue that revealed a fake

The player should never feel:

- “the game cheated and I had no way to know”
 - “I’m just clicking through identical customers”
 - “inventory is a chore instead of a strategy layer”
-

43. Monetization and market positioning

Price target

For a polished indie version:

- **\$12.99–\$19.99** depending on depth and production quality

Positioning statement

This should be sold as: **not just a pawn shop sim** but as: **a negotiation and appraisal strategy game where greed, risk, and hidden value drive every day**

Steam positioning angle

Emphasize:

- shady customers
- hidden treasure
- fake and stolen goods
- collector economy
- cursed relics / weird valuables
- “just one more deal” loop

44. What makes this game stand out from other pawn / shop sims

Your version should not compete by saying:

“We also have shelves and store customization.”

That’s not enough.

It should compete by saying:

Distinctive differentiators

1. **Deep appraisal / uncertainty system**
2. **Negotiation with customer psychology**
3. **Counterfeit and stolen goods as core gameplay**
4. **Collector / set-completion economy**
5. **Optional cursed relic layer for identity**

6. **Short, addictive day-based runs**

7. **Every item can become a story**

That is the actual product.

45. Build order recommendation for Claude Code / development

Phase 1 – Foundation

Build:

- GameState
- ItemDefinition + ItemInstance
- CustomerArchetype + CustomerInstance
- Day loop
- Cash / Reputation / Heat / Debt
- Inventory
- basic UI

Phase 2 – Core deal loop

Build:

- item generation
- customer generation
- inspection clues
- negotiation offers
- buy / reject flow
- item acquisition

Phase 3 – Selling and progression

Build:

- local selling
- collector selling prototype
- day summary
- debt progression
- one upgrade screen

Phase 4 – Risk layers

Build:

- fake items
- suspicious stolen items
- heat events
- simple inspection event

Phase 5 – Content and tuning

Build:

- 40+ items
- 20+ events
- more customer archetypes
- balancing
- polish

Phase 6 – Differentiation layer

Add one strong identity feature:

- cursed relics or
- underworld network or
- elite collector set chains

Do not add all three at once until the core loop is already fun.

46. Final creative direction summary

Pawnshop King should feel like this:

You open your tiny shop in the morning already in debt.

A tired man walks in with a scratched watch and says it belonged to his father.

Maybe he's lying. Maybe he's desperate. Maybe the watch is fake. Maybe it's worth a month of rent if you spot the right detail.

By noon you've bought a suspicious gold ring, rejected a console bundle, and hidden a possibly stolen phone in the back room because a collector might pay triple tomorrow.

By evening you've made money, created risk, and convinced yourself that one more day will solve everything.

That feeling — **greed, uncertainty, pattern recognition, and one-more-day momentum** — is the game.